

4. The group known as 'impatient patients' are more likely to continue with a course of prescribed medication if
- (A) their treatment can be completed over a reduced period of time.
  - (B) it is possible to link their treatment with a financial advantage.
  - (C) its short-term benefits are explained to them.

#### **Medication adherence and impatient patients**

A recent article addressed the behaviour of people who have a 'taste for the present rather than the future'. It proposed that these so-called 'impatient patients' are unlikely to adhere to medications that require use over an extended period. The article proposes that, an 'impatience genotype' exists and that assessing these patients' view of the future while stressing the immediate advantages of adherence may improve adherence rates more than emphasizing potentially distant complications. The authors suggest that rather than attempting to change the character of those who are 'impatient', it may be wise to ascertain the patient's individual priorities, particularly as they relate to immediate gains. For example, while advising an 'impatient' patient with diabetes, stressing improvement in visual acuity rather than avoidance of retinopathy may result in greater medication adherence rates. Additionally, linking the cost of frequently changing prescription lenses when visual acuity fluctuates with glycemic levels may sometimes provide the patient with an immediate financial motivation for improving adherence.